

But is it for everyone? Is RPA really worth the hype? If I invest in RPA, what should I keep in mind? Or first of all, should I invest at all? This article aims to clear any doubts about RPA and help you decide whether or not RPA is a good option for your business.

What is RPA?

In simple terms, robotic process automation (RPA) means automation of any process that is robotic or repetitive in nature. The automation involves the configuration of computer software or bots to mimic 'most' of the actions usually performed by a human to interact with disparate digital systems while executing a business process. The aim is to leave the time-consuming and mundane tasks to RPA so that the employees can focus on tasks that require more strategic and innovative thinking and meet the demands of rapidly evolving markets.

Sirisha, head of industrial engineering and new product launch, Continental Automotive India, says, "Covid-19 pandemic acted as a catalyst for digital transformation in the industry globally, including India. Automation eliminates many of the time-consuming steps involved in manual processes. It can reduce unnecessary costs and improve the quality of outcomes as well."

But what are these tasks? If your work involves logging into different applications like e-mails, connecting to system APIs, filling forms, and simply copying and pasting data from one place to another, then these definitely meet the conditions of RPA. There is a video that explains how RPA is different from traditional automation at <https://www.automationanywhere.com/company/blog/rpa-thought-leadership/robotic-process-automation-at-a-glance>



Types of RPA

There are numerous tools available in the market that automate simple processes to the ones that can be used to make complex decisions. RPA can be broadly classified into attended and unattended automation.

Attended. Imagine that you call the customer representative of a business for a query. What would you like—it takes a long time for the executive to manually find your details and make the necessary update, or it gets done in seconds?

This is the purpose of attended bots—saving time for performing repetitive tasks in real time, which does not follow a specific pattern. It can be on demand where a human involves bots at defined intervals for specific functions or in tandem, where the robot supports the human's work process in the background. These bots run on computers to aid the employees in performing the tasks assigned to them. Invoking these passive bots has to happen either by the user's action, or a window can be defined since the exact points of the launch are hard to detect. Control is then returned to the user by the bot to carry out the next set of activities.

Unattended. By using attended bots, the executive comes up with the client details easily, but when your job is to enter data of several different new clients on various applications daily, it surely gets boring. For this, use unattended bots.

Unattended bots are best for the repetitive structured tasks that can be fully mapped and hence require no user involvement. In case of partially unattended, the human needs to define the parameters for an unattended process to work. This reduces the time taken by users in performing complex tasks that require dealing with high-volume data.

These can be self-triggered and even run on back-end servers 24/7 based on the occurrence of an event such as a predecessor task, a priority-based time slot, or even data input in a field in real time. One bot can even launch another. The best thing? There is no delay in task completion before deadlines.

Hybrid. The goal for businesses, especially large organisations, is to make support and back-end processes more efficient by using the best or a hybrid of both unattended and attended automation. So, basically an attended robot uses the human's computer to start an unattended background process.

Want to know what else is an example of RPA? Try opening a few websites of different companies you wish to contact, and you will see a chatbot on the right-hand side to answer your questions in most of them. Most sites we visit these days have chatbots or virtual assistants that use natural language processing to analyse data in real time and interact with users. In certain instances, the data is given to the human professional for a better understanding of customer requirements.

RPA itself cannot learn from experience or interpret meaning like AI. As people are taking more interest in the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) with RPA for intelligent automation, performing cognitive tasks via machine learning (ML) that need handling of complex unstructured data (not organised in a database) will become possible.

Manish Bharti, president - India and South Asia, UiPath, says, "By combining attended and unattended automation, chatbots provide a rich user interface, by being able to converse with people and other robots in the workflow. Early this year, we partnered with Druid, and integrated their no-code, AI-powered chatbot into the UiPath Platform."

Use cases of process automation in customer support services

Be it B2B or B2C, customers are the priority of a business. Recent studies show that the use of bots for customer service is going to further increase in the coming years since most processes like payment processing, email communication, and processing forms can be done with RPA. Take the example of system queries. Since any organisation will have several applications that are usually not integrated, manually compiling data would be quite tedious. RPA can collect data from all applications, including databases from servers, and provide the user with consolidated data.

Voicebot. It is based on AI and is a more advanced version of an auto-attendant system. It is great for handling automated tasks that involve numbers and simple yes/no answers. Voicebot with natural